Understanding Consumer Response to Sponsorship Information: A Resource-Matching Approach

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ABSTRACT

Sponsorship of sporting teams and events has become an increasingly popular form of corporate and brand communication. Despite the continued growth of sponsorship spending, the corresponding literature base is highly fragmented and little agreement exists related to the psychological mechanisms underlying response. This paper integrates several prominent sponsorship research streams in promoting a "resource-matching" perspective of cognitive elaboration and attitude change. This research holds that in the absence of clear functional fit between sponsor and event, identifying a basis for sponsor–event fit is likely to require some degree of cognitive effort. The results indicate stronger social identification with the sponsored event influences the favorability they attribute to sponsor motives and promotes stronger perceptions of fit between the sponsor and the sponsored activity. Further, the results indicate fit perceptions mediate the relationship between attribution and sponsorship response. Consistent with ELM theory, when cognitive resources are insufficient for the complexity of the fit-matching task, social identification may still act as a peripheral cue in driving a positive affective response to sponsorship information. © 2012 Wiley Periodicals, Inc.

INTRODUCTION

Despite broad-based adoption of sponsorship-based marketing programs, relatively little agreement exists on how consumers process and utilize this information (Pham & Vanhuele, 1997). The early sponsorship literature focused heavily upon legitimizing the business value of its practice, causing later scholars to note a lack of underlying theory (e.g., Cornwell & Maignan, 1998). Such calls have led to a surge in more theoretically inclined work aimed at investigating responses to sponsorship stimuli. Notwithstanding notable advances within this stream, the various strands of research examining the mechanics of consumer-focused sponsorship communications remain heavily fragmented in spite of potential complementarities (Cornwell, Weeks & Roy, 2005). That is, research into consumer response to sponsorship has focused on individual elements of explanation, rather than on the provision of a generalized model which might facilitate the overall understanding of the phenomenon (Meenaghan, 2001). For the most part, linkages between these mechanisms remain unexplored and no unifying framework has yet emerged.

Reviews of the literature show the preponderance of sponsorship effects research has investigated the practice's impact on consumer awareness and perceptions of corporate image (Cornwell & Maignan, 1998; Walliser, 2003). While these studies have applied a variety of theoretical perspectives in explaining sponsorship response, most share an emphasis on affective transference of goodwill or image from the property to the sponsor as their mechanismic explanation. Overwhelmingly, such studies have neglected or minimized the role of cognition in sponsorship information processing and response. This gap is significant in two ways. First, Keller (1993) stipulates the concept of brand image refers to the *cognitive associations* held in consumers' minds about the brand. As a result, favorably altering a firm's brand image through sponsorship and sponsorship-related activation, by definition, must entail some cognitive processing. Second, while

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image- and awareness-related objectives indeed are routinely identified in surveys of sponsorship decision makers, most sponsors rank building brand loyalty and driving sales as goals of equal, if not greater, significance (Ukman, 2008). Observers have noted that this intense focus on certain outcomes and explanations, to the neglect of other key outcomes and complementary processes, has limited the practical usefulness of much sponsorship research (e.g., Andrews, 2007).

While some firms see sponsorship principally as a means to create awareness or to enhance public perception of their brands, others seek to utilize sponsorship as a way of differentiating their products and services by tethering them to issues, events, and organizations that customers care deeply about (e.g., Ukman, 2008). That is, in the absence of tangible differences in products, sponsorship may help to win over customers who are deeply engaged with the sponsored entity. Of the studies that have considered the effects of sponsorship upon persuasion, few have ventured beyond the notion of sponsorship as a peripheral cue, again leaving the cognitive aspects of sponsorship information processing and response comparatively under-researched.

This paper emphasizes a "resource-matching" perspective of cognitive elaboration and attitude change (e.g., Anand & Sternthal, 1989; Coulter, 2005; Hu, Huhmann, & Hyman, 2007; Martin, Sharrard, & Wentzel, 2005; Mothersbaugh, Huhmann, & Franke, 2002) in investigating consumer responses to sponsorship. Grounded within the ELM, the resource-matching view posits message processing is optimized when available processing resources match required cognitive demands (Keller & Block, 1997). In turn, the resources available to process incoming information are determined by an individual's ability and motivation to elaborate.

The application of this resource-matching framework to the sponsorship context represents a major contribution of this paper, as it enables the integration of previously disjointed views of sponsorship effects—based in social identification, attribution, and congruence theories, respectively. In the absence of clear functional fit between the sponsor and the activity, which is the most common case empirically, identifying a basis for fit is likely to require more extensive cognitive effort. In such instances, it is proposed that the message relevance of sponsorship information will be higher for individuals with high social identification with the sponsored activity, creating greater motivation for them to elaborate upon the nature of the sponsor–event relationship. This added elaboration should lead individuals to devote greater cognitive resources toward (a) devising naïve theories in attributing sponsors' motives, and (b) identifying a basis for perceived fit between the sponsor and activity. When cognitive resources are insufficient to motivate deeper elaboration, social identification may still act as a peripheral cue in prompting favorable consumer responses. Thus, in accordance with the ELM's dual-process approach, links between fit and sponsorship response (i.e., central processing) are hypothesized as well as a more affective path between social identification and response (i.e., peripheral processing). The conceptual model is presented in Figure 1.

LITERATURE REVIEW

Most research on consumer-focused sponsorship states or assumes an associative memory model, as discussed in the marketing literature by Keller (1993). As such, sponsorship researchers have focused on the individual and environmental factors believed to influence brand recall, brand recognition, or brand associations held in memory. This study contributes to the literature by integrating three of the more commonly applied theoretical lenses (social identification, schema, and attribution theories) within the field into a single framework. Readers are referred to Cornwell, Weeks, and Roy (2005) for a more extensive review of the sponsorship effects literature.

Social Identification Theory

Social identity refers to "that part of an individual's self-concept which derives from his knowledge of his membership of a social group(s) together with the value and emotional significance attached to that membership" (Tajfel, 1981, p. 255). This view proposes that people make social classifications as a means of locating themselves and defining others within a social environment (e.g., Tajfel & Turner, 1985), ultimately influencing their attitudes and behaviors (Laverie & Arnett, 2000). Organizational research has shown that when an individual identifies with an employing firm, they become personally vested in its performance, leading to actions that promote its chances of success (Mael & Ashforth, 1992).

Branscombe and Wann (1991) proposed that people may possess many different social identities, including an identity derived from an attachment to a particular sports team or event. Studies have shown that the salience of a given identity can greatly influence consumer decision making (Reed, 2002, 2004). In a study of adults attending a college football game, Madrigal (2000) found that social identification was a positive predictor of sponsor product purchase intentions, a relationship that was strengthened when individuals perceived such intentions were perceived as a group norm. Madrigal (2001) established that social identification positively moderated the relationship between brand attitudes and purchase intentions. Gwinner and Swanson (2003) found social identification also influenced other key sponsorship outcomes, including sponsor recognition, attitude toward the sponsor, sponsor patronage, and satisfaction with sponsors. Thus, in sum, research has supported the usefulness of social identification in explaining organizational outcomes in several contexts, including sponsorship.

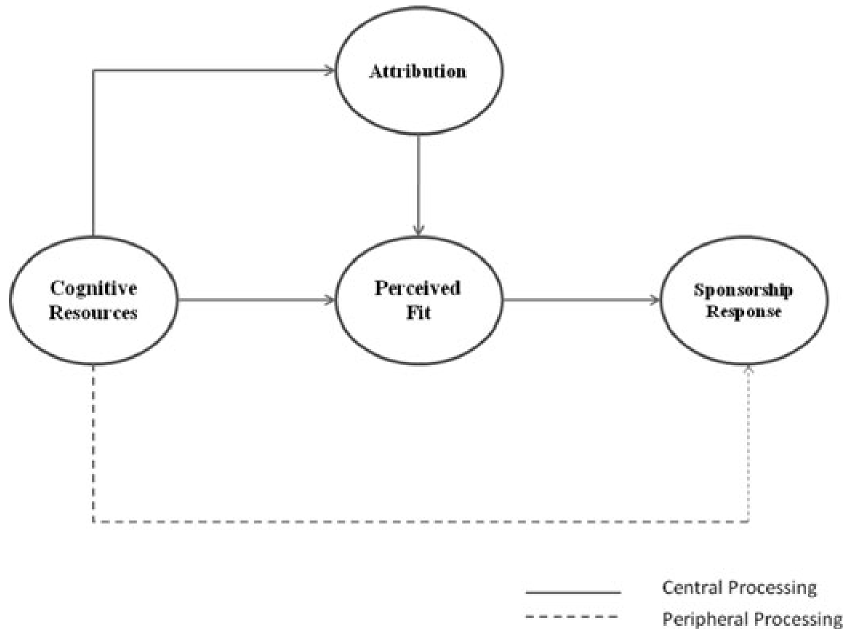

Figure 1. Resource matching in sponsorship: conceptual model. If available cognitive resources are sufficient for the complexity of the fit-matching task, more extensive elaboration will ensue resulting in a favorable evaluative response through the direct processing route. When cognitive resources are insufficient for the complexity of the fit-matching task, the presence of a strong heuristic cue may still lead to a favorable evaluative response through the peripheral processing route. When cognitive resources greatly exceed that required for the fit-matching task, excess resources may be used to generate either additional supportive arguments or counter-arguments. In the case of sponsor–event fit perceptions, additional arguments are likely to be qualitatively biased in favor of greater fit when the individual is highly identified with the sponsored event or property.

Schema Theory

Schema theory suggests that the accessibility of information stored in memory is influenced by relatedness or similarity, such that viewing a running event sponsored by a shoe retailer seems appropriate to the consumer and is more easily remembered. In turn, fit has been found to favorably influence brand equity by bolstering consumer attitudes, intentions, and behaviors toward sponsor brands (Becker-Olsen & Hill, 2006; Koo, Quarterman, & Flynn 2006). The concept of sponsor and event fit is the most thoroughly investigated theoretical concept relating to improved consumer processing of sponsorship stimuli (e..g., Cornwell, 1995; Gwinner & Eaton, 1999; Johar & Pham, 1999; McDaniel, 1999). Moreover, the appropriateness of schema- and attribution-based explanations for sponsorship effects has been bolstered by qualitative studies, in which researchers have consistently identified related themes in coding unprompted consumer comments on the topic (e.g., Hill, Deitz & Branch, 2003; Meenaghan, 2001).

While memory effects of strong fit have been consistently supported in experimental studies, the effects of moderate incongruence have only been examined as a lack of fit and have not been investigated in its own right (Cornwell, Weeks, & Roy, 2005). In addition, most sponsorship studies have simply conceptualized fit on a functional basis, that is, whether or not the sponsored brand may be used in the sponsored event or activity. Many sponsorship relationships, however, involve sponsor–activity pairings for which fit might best be described as ambiguous. This is a notable gap, given that several authors have proposed that consumer fit judgments may be made on a variety of bases. For instance, Pentecost and Spence (2004) used a small number of managerial interviews to explore the potential variations of fit, uncovering six distinct dimensions of fit: targeting, image, geography, typicality, complementarily, and clash. In a study of consumers, Gwinner and Eaton (1999) distinguished between functional fit and image-based fit. Rather than concentrating on a single basis of fit (high vs. low functional fit) as in much prior work, this study focuses more broadly upon fit perceptions as being represented by the relative strength of the mental associations consumers are able to make between a sponsoring brand and a sponsored entity, such as a team, event, venue, or organization (e.g., Speed & Thompson, 2000; Gwinner & Bennett, 2008).

Attribution Theory

According to attribution theory, individuals act as naïve scientists, enacting cognitive processes by which they attempt to develop commonsense explanations for why actions have occurred (Heider, 1958). In turn, a person's causal analysis of events influences her subsequent attitudes, feelings, and behaviors (Kelley, 1967). Even though these attributions may be riddled with biases and distortions, establishing such attributions enables individuals to achieve a greater level of understanding and control over their lives and environment. Within consumer psychology, prior research has investigated the role of attributions in a wide number of contexts, including evaluations of product purchases and failures (Curren & Folkes, 1987), celebrity endorsements (Wiener & Mowen, 1986), cause-related marketing (Webb & Mohr, 1998), and brand-switching behaviors (Mazursky, La Barbera, & Aiello, 1987).

Research on celebrity endorsements, a body of research closely related to sponsorship, indicates that consumers will question if an endorser's claims are made because they are truthful or the result of situational factors. If the latter is believed, the endorsement will be discounted (Kelley, 1973). For instance, Folkes (1988) found that consumers responded more favorably to a Chrysler advertisement featuring Frank Sinatra when they learned that Sinatra was being compensated at the rate of $1 per year as opposed to when they were given no information about the entertainer's compensation. Empirical research has shown that sponsors that are perceived as sincere and motivated by philanthropy achieved superior responses from consumers compared to those seen as motivated purely by commercial considerations (Armstrong, 1988; D'Astous & Bitz, 1995). In a more recent investigation of a charitable event sponsorship, Dean (2002) found that positive attributions were closely linked to favorable sponsorship outcomes.

CONCEPTUAL DEVELOPMENT

The research model presented here is grounded in a resource-matching view of elaboration likelihood. The "resource-matching" hypothesis holds that message persuasiveness is highest when available cognitive resources match the demands of a given mental task (Keller & Block, 1997). Within this view, cognitive efficiency is thought to be greatest when consumers possess high motivation and ability (i.e., cognitive resources), given opportunity to process the information (Kang & Herr, 2006). Ability is determined by both situational factors (e.g., repetition, distraction) and individual differences (e.g., knowledge), whereas motivation is influenced solely by individual differences, such as need for cognition (Haugtvedt, Petty, & Cacioppo, 1992) and personal relevance of the communication (Petty & Wegener, 1999).

The underlying theory behind this stream of research evolved from early studies on the effects of advertising repetition (Batra & Ray, 1986; Calder & Sternthal, 1980). Cacioppo and Petty (1979) proposed that when first exposed to an advertisement, individuals will attempt to assimilate its content and most of their thoughts will be consistent with those advocated in its message. Beyond a certain number of exposures, however, habituation occurs, leading to depletion in the number of support arguments and greater counterargumentation. Anand and Sternthal (1989) extended this line of thinking to a single communication, suggesting the persuasive impact of a message will be optimized when resources allocated to processing it match task demands. When cognitive resources are limited, individuals cope using heuristic processing, whereby information processed is minimized and judgments are made based upon peripheral cues (Peracchio & Meyers-Levy, 1997).

The resource-matching perspective offers a means of integrating several distinct and heretofore disjointed strands of sponsorship research. Assuming a sponsor–event pairing of moderate complexity, it is proposed that persuasion in response to sponsorship information may occur through multiple routes, with social identification acting as the key exogenous variable. High social identification with the sponsored property increases an individual's motivation to elaborate upon new sponsorship information. Provided that the complexity of the cognitive task does not outstrip the level of currently available resources, it is expected that highly identified individuals will more deeply consider the nature of the relationship between the sponsor and their favored activity. If the complexity of the mental task outstrips the individual's motivation and ability to elaborate, the salience of an individual's social identity with the sponsored entity may nonetheless influence response affectively by serving as a heuristic cue. Over the following sections, formal hypotheses are developed in support of the proposed model.

Social Identification and Perceived Fit

Given the demands on consumers' time and information processing capacity, individuals require means of distinguishing between which stimuli should be scrutinized carefully and those that are not worthy of extensive thought (Petty, Cacioppo, & Schumann, 1983). It is proposed that an individual's level of social identification with the sponsored activity is a trait that is likely to influence the personal relevance of new sponsorship information. Roy and Cornwell (2004) suggested consumers with greater levels of knowledge about a sponsored activity appeared to utilize information stored in memory when elaborating on a sponsorship message and were better able to elicit more thoughts about the sponsor than consumers less knowledgeable about the event. High social identification is expected to similarly influence cognitive elaboration, vis-à-vis consumers' perceptions of sponsor–event fit and attributions of sponsor motives.

By sponsoring consumer-favored activities and leveraging that relationship through sponsorship-themed advertising and sales promotions, firms seek to connect their brands to cognitive (e.g., does use of the brand signify that I am a fan?), normative (e.g., does the use of this brand show others that I am a fan?), and affective (e.g., does the use of this brand show my affection for the team?) social identity components (Ellemers, Kortekaas, & Ouwerkerd, 1999). Since highly identified individuals are more apt to evaluate incoming information in terms of their group membership, how well new information matches with a group identity will likely play a key role in determining the level of effort they put into processing the information. In the case of sponsorship information, stronger identification should motivate individuals to allocate additional resources in considering the basis of fit between the sponsor and sponsored activity. This is clearly a cognition-driven activity, one that those low in identification need not pursue because the team or event does not impact or reflect their self-concept (Wann et al., 2006).

Such a view is consistent with previous research examining how experts and novices process sponsor pairings. For instance, Roy and Cornwell (2004) found that experts elicited more overall thoughts about event pairings and had a significantly higher number of negative thoughts about the sponsor–event combination than novices. Consistent with the theoretical evidence, it is expected that greater levels of social identification will motivate more extensive elaboration on the part of individuals, independent of their attributions of sponsor motives, leading directly to strengthened perceptions of sponsor–event fit. Hence, it is proposed:

H1 An individual's social identification with the sponsored event will be positively associated with perceived sponsor–event fit.

Social Identification and Attributions of Sponsor Motive

Parallel to the motives of celebrity endorsers, firms may be viewed as sponsoring an event because the corporation views it as worthy (i.e., an intrinsic or goodwill motive) or because it seeks to profit financially or enhance its reputation (i.e., extrinsic or sales motive; Madrigal, 2001). Prior sponsorship research indicates intrinsic attributions exert a more favorable influence on subsequent attitudes and behavior (Dean, 2002; Rifon et al., 2004). Similarly, Ruth and Simonin (2006) found that goodwill-minded sponsors receive more positive evaluations.

Attributions may be qualitatively affected by motivational biases which arise from a need to protect one's self-esteem (e.g., Folkes, 1988). This esteem bias represents the tendency to attribute positive outcomes internally and negative outcomes externally. When self-esteem and identity are rooted in an individual's affinity to a favored activity, such as a team or cause, prior research likewise supports the notion that social identification leads to biases in cognitive appraisals (e.g., Wann & Branscombe, 1995; Wann, Melnick, Russell, & Pease, 2001). For example, Wann et al. (2006) found highly identified aficionados of a collegiate sports team reported more positive evaluations when a prospective player was presented as a recruit for their team as compared to when the player was presented as a rival's recruit. In making attributions of sponsor motives, it is expected that more highly identified fans will be motivated to attribute the sponsor's relationship of the team or event to intrinsic factors rather than extrinsic ones, due to their viewing the team or event as an extension of their own identity. It is predicted that:

H2 An individual's social identification with the sponsored activity will be positively associated with the favorability of their perceived attributions of sponsor motives.

Perceived Fit as a Mediator for Sponsorship Response

The impact of sponsor attributions upon concurrent or subsequent cognitive appraisals, such as perceived sponsor–event fit, has received insufficient attention. Rifon et al. (2004) linked the attribution-based explanation with congruence theory, suggesting close-fitting sponsors would be perceived as more credible. These authors proposed that increases in elaboration generated by an incongruent sponsor-cause match would lead to message counter-argumentation, which in turn, would lead to negative attributions.

In the present study, it is likewise believed that the relationship between fit and attribution is an important one. This research differs from Rifon et al. (2004), however, in the causal ordering of the variables. It is noted here that their study experimentally manipulated fit into high–low categories. That is, for those researchers, the cognitive processes that direct individual perceptions under more ambiguous sponsor–event matches were not of concern. While their argument is adequately supported and their analysis sound, the proposed causal ordering and conclusions drawn from their results can be interpreted, at least in part, as owing to their design.

This research empirically investigates this matter, hypothesizing perceived fit will mediate the effects of attribution upon sponsorship response. To be clear, the current study does not pose a direct argument to Rifon et al.'s (2004) design or analysis. Depending upon the aims of the research, however, it is more generally suggested here that dichotomizing fit into extreme high and low categories may be somewhat limiting in terms of advancing the stream. First, empirically speaking, the vast majority of real world sponsor–event pairings are not easily categorized into high- and low-fit groupings (Cornwell, Humphreys, Maguire, Weeks, & Tellegen, 2006). Second, from a conceptual perspective, recent research notes sponsor–event fit perceptions may rest upon multiple dimensions (e.g., image based) that may not be mutually exclusive (Gwinner & Eaton, 1999; Poon & Prendergast, 2006). Third, in terms of theory development, experimental manipulation of fit negates the ability of researchers to investigate individual and contextual drivers of fit perceptions or examine the role of fit perceptions within a more complex nomological network of variables.

In summary, this research expresses that (a) the level of *functional* fit for most event–sponsor pairs would at best be described as moderate, and (b) perceptions of sponsor–event fit can be concurrently formed on multiple bases. Some consumers may develop fit perceptions based on functionality, whereas others may concentrate on an image match. Still others may examine product attributes or perceive a better fit for local sponsors (Pentecost & Spence, 2004). These issues combine to suggest fit perceptions may differ considerably across consumers and sponsor–event pairs. If so, the techniques and conditions by which fit perceptions and subsequent responses to sponsorship information are enhanced should be of keen interest to scholars and managers.

Since people tend to seek information that confirms their attributions (Scott & Yalch, 1980), increased elaboration relating to sponsors' intentions should lead them to devote additional resources in identifying the basis for sponsor–event fit as well as to create associations that are consistent with their biases. Thus, positive attributions of sponsor motive should have quantitative as well as qualitative effects on fit perceptions, directing both the intensity and the content of increased elaboration. Increased fit perceptions, in turn, should lead to more favorable sponsorship response. The conceptual link between perceived fit and sponsorship response is well established within sponsorship research and is consistent with schema-based work related to other marketing phenomena (e.g., brand extensions, celebrity endorsers). In general, categorization theory suggests people divide the world into categories that enable them to efficiently process information within their environment (e.g., Sujan, 1985). When a new stimulus is presented, the receiver attempts to match it with an existing category evoked from memory; a stronger match should make it easier to develop an associative link (Till & Nowak, 2000). If a close fitting match is found, this schema is more likely to be activated in evaluating the targeted product, generally resulting in greater and more rapid recall (Nedungadi & Hutchinson, 1985) and enhanced relevance (Kamins & Gupta, 1994).

When this information fits with a pre-existing schema, this close correspondence improves sponsor recall (Levin, Joiner & Cameron, 2001), enhances image transfer (Gwinner and Eaton 1999), positively influences thoughts about the sponsor (Crimmins & Horn, 1996), bolsters attitudes toward the sponsor (Ellen, Mohr & Webb, 2000), directs choice behavior (Pracejus & Olsen, 2004), and increases sponsor likeability (Haley, 1996). Speed and Thompson's (2000) study found perceived fit directly influenced sponsor awareness, favorability, and product use. Based upon the preceding discussion, it is expected:

H3 Perceived sponsor–event fit will mediate the relationship between the favorability of an individual's attributions of sponsor motive and sponsorship response.

Social Identification and Sponsorship Response

When available resources are insufficient to effectively process sponsorship information, response will depend upon the salience of heuristic cues. Petty, Cacioppo, and Goldman (1983) suggest peripheral cues (e.g., source credibility, attractiveness) may shape attitudes or allow a person to decide what attitudinal position to adopt without the need for engaging in extensive issue-relevant thinking. Furthermore, such cues may influence attitudes, irrespective of whether any issue-relevant arguments are presented or considered (e.g., Maddux & Rogers, 1980). Thus, in addition to influencing sponsorship response by motivating more extensive elaboration, social identification should also have a direct effect on individuals' responses to sponsorship information.

The direct conceptual link between social identification and sponsorship response has been consistently supported. Gwinner and Swanson (2003) reported that identification was positively associated with a host of sponsorship outcomes, including recognition, attitude toward sponsors, patronage, and satisfaction. Research also indicates that team identification is positively associated with sponsor brand awareness and purchase intentions (Madrigal, 2000). An individual's strong social identification with a team or event should make the activation of this aspect of her identity more likely. Even in the absence of greater elaboration in response to complex stimuli, social identification may still lead to an affectively based positive response to sponsorship information (Bagozzi & Lee, 2002). That is, via a strong commitment to the group, there will be an automatic transfer of affect from the group to the sponsor. Therefore, it is expected that:

H4 An individual's level of social identification with the sponsored event will be positively associated with sponsorship response.

METHOD

Consistent with prior sponsorship work (e.g., Johar & Pham, 1999), a simulated press-release paradigm was employed. First, respondents read a brief description of the sponsor firm's operations (see Table 1) and were then asked to rate their image of the company. A fictitious snack food company was selected as the sponsor for two reasons. First, the snack food category appears to consist of products with neither a particularly high or low level of functional fit with college athletics; that is, its fit is sufficiently ambiguous for the purposes of this study. This belief was bolstered by the results of a pretest study, in which six potential university athletics' sponsors were ranked according to the extent to which they "made sense" as a sponsor of the university's athletic programs. Snack food (mean = 3.85) ranked

Table 1. Measurement Model.

	EST	S/E	t
Social Identification (Source: Mael & Ashworthe, 1992)			
When I hear someone praise a University of _____ athletics team, it feels like a personal compliment.	1.00	0.00	
When someone criticizes University of _____ athletics, it feels like a personal insult.	0.96	0.06	15.69
When I talk about University of _____ athletics, I usually say “we” rather than “they.”	0.92	0.07	13.24
If a story in the media criticized University of _____ athletics, I would feel embarrassed.	0.84	0.07	12.13
I am very interested in what others think about University of _____ athletics.	0.85	0.07	12.80
When a University of _____ athletics team succeeds, I feel like I’ve succeeded.	0.93	0.06	15.43
Sponsor Attributions (Source: Speed & Thompson, 2000)			
This sponsor is likely to have the best interests of ________ at heart.	1.00	0.00	
The main reason this sponsor would be involved with _______ is because the sponsor believes it deserves support.	0.84	0.11	7.76
This sponsor would probably support ________ even if it had a much lower profile.	0.86	0.11	7.86
Perceived Fit (Source: Speed & Thompson, 2000)			
The sponsor and the event fit together well.	1.00	0.00	
The image of the event and the image of the sponsor are similar.	0.96	0.09	10.72
It makes sense to me that this company sponsors this event.	0.82	0.09	9.40
Sponsorship Response (Source: Speed & Thompson, 2000) *This sponsorship . . .*			
Would make me more likely to use the sponsor’s product. (Intent)	1.00	0.00	
Would more likely make me buy from the sponsor as a result of this sponsorship. (Intent)	0.94	0.07	15.28
Would improve my perception of the sponsor. (Favorability)	0.57	0.07	8.32
Would make me feel more favorable toward the sponsor. (Favorability)	0.73	0.07	10.81
Would make me more likely to notice the sponsor’s name on other occasions. (Interest)	0.97	0.07	14.52
Would make me more likely to remember the sponsor’s promotion. (Interest)	0.94	0.07	14.20
(Prior) Attitude toward Sponsor (Source: Bruner & Hensel, 1992)			
Company ABC is a regional manufacturer of snack food, ranging from various flavors of potato and corn chips to pretzels. Company ABC is based in a nearby city and serves a twelve-state region in the southeastern USA. In 2002, the company reported gross revenue of about $100 million dollars.			
Based upon the preceding description, my attitude toward this company could best be categorized as:			
Like . . . . Dislike	1.00	0.00	
Bad . . . . Good	0.91	0.07	13.86
Favorable . . . . Unfavorable	0.99	0.06	15.73
Measurement Model Fit Statistics			
Satorra–Bentler $\chi^2_{(178)} = 258.4$, $p < 0.01$.			
RMSEA = 0.055; CFI = 0.96; TLI – 0.96; SRMR = 0.046.			

significantly lower ($t = -9.76$, $p < 0.00$) than the highest fitting category, athletic apparel (mean = 1.44), and significantly higher ($t = 11.46$, $p < 0.00$) than the lowest fitting category, cosmetics (mean = 5.56). Second, snack foods are a common food item consumed by most of the population. Therefore, respondents should possess sufficient levels of product knowledge and experience for them to make assessments of sponsor–event fit as well as consider how sponsorship information would affect their interest in sponsor advertising and promotions, feelings of favorability toward, the sponsor and purchase intentions.

As part of a class project for an undergraduate marketing research course, a pencil-and-paper survey was administered to a student-recruited sample of 151 respondents in the southern USA. Student teams were trained how to properly administer the survey and were given explicit guidelines regarding desired sample characteristics (e.g., roughly equal number of male/female, over 30 years/under 30 years). Four surveys were eliminated because of incomplete responses. Of the final sample, eighty-six respondents (58.5%) were male with an overall mean age of just over 25 years old.

All measures were drawn from prior research. After reading the initial description of the sponsor firm, respondents were asked to describe their attitudes toward the company using a three-item semantic differential scale (e.g., *My attitude toward this company could best be categorized as: like ... dislike*; Bruner & Hensel, 1992). Respondents were subsequently exposed to a fictitious press release informing them of the firm's sponsorship of the athletic program of their favored university (e.g., *Company ABC recently reached a sponsorship agreement with the University of ______ athletic department to provide $250,000 in return for advertising and promotional rights to various athletic events over a five-year period.*). Measures of perceived sponsor–activity fit and attributions of sponsor motive were drawn from Speed and Thompson's five-item Likert scale (2000). To avoid implying any particular basis for fit, these statements referred to abstract notions of fit, such as similarity, a logical connection, and making sense (e.g., *It makes sense to me that this company sponsors this event.*) Attribution of sponsor motive was captured using three items (e.g., *This sponsor is likely to have the best interests of ________ at heart*.). Next, respondents were assessed on individual differences. Six items from Mael and Ashworth's (1992) organizational identification scale were adapted to measure team social identification (e.g., *When a University of _____ athletic team succeeds, I feel like I've succeeded.*).

Sponsorship response was operationalized as a second-order factor representing respondents' attitudes and intentions at three different levels of the hierarchy of effects (Speed & Thompson, 2000). Respondents indicated the extent to which they believed the sponsorship would affect their interest in the sponsor (e.g., *This sponsorship ... would make me more likely to remember the sponsor's promotion.*), their favorability toward the sponsor (e.g., *This sponsorship ... would improve my perception of the sponsor.*), and their willingness to consider the sponsor's product (e.g., *This sponsorship ... would make me more likely to use the sponsor's product*.).

Controls

The effects of prior sponsor attitudes on all endogenous variables were controlled, in recognition of prior research that suggests sponsors with more favorable images receive greater benefit from sponsorship activities (e.g., Stipp & Schiavone, 1996). Because theory suggests older respondents may possess more established brand associations and preferences (Keller, 1993), the effects of age on perceived fit and sponsorship response were also incorporated.

MEASUREMENT

Table 1 provides all construct items and factor loadings as well as overall measurement model fit statistics. All scales proved sufficiently reliable, with composite reliabilities ranging from 0.79 (sponsor attribution) to 0.93 (social identification). Unidimensionality was assessed through confirmatory factor analysis of all items and latent constructs using MPlus 5.2 (Muthen & Muthen, 2006). Goodness-of-fit indices suggest the measurement model is an appropriate fit to the data: $\chi^2_{(187)} = 258.4$, $p < .01$; root mean square error of approximation [RMSEA] = 0.055; comparative fit index [CFI] = 0.96; Tucker-Lewis index [TLI] = 0.96; standardized root mean square residual [SRMR] = 0.046. All estimated factor loadings were significant and all standardized estimates exceeded 0.60, suggesting convergence of the indicators upon their appropriate underlying factors (Anderson & Gerbing, 1988). Average variance extracted (AVE) for study constructs ranged from 0.56 to 0.79, providing added support for convergent validity. Further, the square root of the AVE for each construct was larger than its respective greatest shared variance with another factor, demonstrating evidence of discriminant validity (Fornell & Larcker, 1981). Composite reliabilities, average variance extracted, and interfactor correlations for study variables are presented in Table 2.

RESULTS

Goodness-of-fit statistics for the theorized structural model indicate the data are a reasonable fit for the proposed model: $\chi^2_{297} = 400.2$ ($p < 0.01$); RMSEA = 0.057; CFI = 0.96; TLI = 0.95; SRMR = 0.049. H1, which predicted a significant direct path between social identification and perceived fit, could not be supported by the data ($\beta = 0.12$, $t = 1.34$, $p < 0.18$). H2 proposed an individual's social identification with the event would be positively associated with the favorability of their attribution of sponsor motives. This path was sustained ($\beta = 0.31$, $t = 3.08$, $p < 0.01$). In addition, because the favorability of the respondents' prior image of the sponsor (i.e., measured before they were exposed to the simulated press release) was controlled for, the results indicate this effect works independently of pre-existing associations relating to the sponsor.

H3 stated perceived fit would mediate the path between individuals' attributions of sponsor motives and sponsorship response. This hypothesis was tested following procedures set forth by Iacobucci, Salanha, and Deng (2007), who updated the standard approach advanced by Baron and Kenney (1986) and Sobel (1982) for SEM. Using simulation data, Iacobucci et al. (2007) offer empirical evidence of the superiority of using SEM for mediation testing, particularly for cases like this in which multiple indicators are available for study constructs, when samples are in the small to moderate

Table 2. Correlation Matrix.

	Mean	SD	CR	ID	Attrib	Fit	Response	Image
Social Identification	2.43	0.13	0.93	**0.83**				
Attributions	4.25	0.46	0.79	0.34	**0.75**			
Perceived Fit	3.36	0.36	0.84	0.31	0.57	**0.80**		
S'ship Response	3.09	0.37	0.92	0.37	0.42	0.64	**0.81**	
Attitude – Sponsor	2.83	0.03	0.92	0.10	0.14	0.16	0.20	**0.89**

Note: Diagonal entries (**in bold**) are the square root of the average variance extracted (AVE). Off-diagonal entries are correlations between latent variables.
* $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; $n = 147$.

size range ($n < 200$), and in particular, when the mediating relationship is embedded within a more complex nomological network. The perceived fit to sponsorship response path was significant ($\beta = 0.72$, $t = 5.61$, $p < 0.01$) as was the path between sponsor attributions and perceived fit ($\beta = 0.48$, $t = 4.74$, $p < 0.01$). The corresponding Sobel (1982) test produced a significant test statistic ($z = 3.35$, $p < .01$), conferring the notion that the indirect effect of attribution on response is mediated by fit. A direct path between attributions and sponsorship response was subsequently added. This path was not significant ($\beta = 0.06$, $t = 0.49$, $p = 0.62$), suggesting perceived fit fully mediated the effects of sponsor attributions upon sponsorship response.

To assess the validity of the proposed causal ordering of the variables (attribution → fit → response) against that advanced by Rifon et al. (2004) (fit → attribution → response), an alternative model was also tested, in which sponsor attributions fully mediated the path between perceived fit and sponsorship response. Fit indices worsened for the alternative model (RMSEA = 0.064; CFI = 0.95; TLI = 0.94; SRMR = 0.071; AIC increased from 10,188 to 10,212; BIC increased from 10,171 to 10,194). Next, a direct path between perceived fit and response was added, which resulted in the attribution to response path becoming non-significant in the alternative model. The Sobel test statistic for the mediated path was also non-significant ($z = 0.26$, $p = 0.79$). Based upon these results, H3 was fully upheld, supporting the proposed causal ordering of variables.

Lastly, H4 suggested that social identification would directly influence response to sponsorship information. This path was found significant ($\beta = 0.22$, $t = 2.82$, $p < 0.01$), which suggests social identification may direct attitudes and behaviors through an affective mechanism as well as by motivating and influencing greater elaboration through central route processing. R^2 scores indicate the theorized model explains 0.45, 0.34, and 0.13 of the variance in sponsorship response, perceived fit, and favorability of sponsor attributions, respectively.

Given the non-significant results for H1, additional tests were run to ascertain the significance of the indirect effects of social identification upon fit via attribution. The indirect effect was significant ($\beta = 0.17$, $t = 3.06$, $p < 0.01$), suggesting the influence of increased cognitive resources available to highly identified team or event devotees upon perceptions of fit were channeled mainly through their attributions of sponsor motives. Table 3 provides full structural model results.

DISCUSSION

In reviewing the body of sponsorship research, Meenaghan and O'Sullivan (2001) wrote "what is clearly lacking is the kind of work that might underpin a comprehensive and unified theoretical framework that would seek to explain how sponsorship actually works" (pp. 88–89). This study seeks in part to address this gap, advancing a resource-matching perspective of sponsorship processing that grounds several different mechanismic explanations for sponsorship response into a single ELM-based framework. The ELM has been successfully advanced as a general framework for organizing, categorizing, and understanding the effectiveness of persuasive communications across the social psychology, consumer behavior, and advertising literatures. Its application in the sponsorship context not only offers the potential for fusing various strands of sponsorship research, but it also serves to link sponsorship to the broader body of marketing and consumer psychology research. Moving forward, this base model could set the stage for ongoing research that will enrich sponsorship theory and enhance its practical worth.

The resource-matching perspective suggests messages are most persuasive when available cognitive resources match the demands of a given task (Anand & Sternthal, 1989; Keller & Block, 1997; Peracchio & Meyers-Levy, 1997). That is, the resources available to process incoming information are determined by an individual's ability and motivation to elaborate. In this model, an individual's level of social identification with her team or event was proposed to indicate the message relevance of sponsorship information. Thus, highly identified individuals will possess relatively greater motivation to cognitively elaborate upon message content in considering sponsor motives and identifying a basis of fit between the sponsor and event. Perceived fit, in turn, leads to more favorable response to sponsorship information and also mediates the attribution to response path. Thus, the model results highlight the central role fit perceptions play in driving sponsorship response. In this study, this elaboration is guided by a social identification based predisposition to look for sponsor–event linkages. In instances when the

Table 3. Structural Model Results.

Paths/Hypotheses	Estimate	t-test	Significance
Social ID → Fit (H1)	0.12	1.34	$p < .18$
Social ID → Attributions (H2)	0.37	3.36	$p < .01$
Attributions → Perceived Fit (H3)	0.47	4.94	$p < .01$
Fit → Sponsorship Response (H3)	0.63	6.19	$p < .01$
Attributions → Sponsorship Response (H3*)	0.01	0.13	0.72
Social ID → Sponsorship Response (H4)	0.20	2.18	$p < 0.01$
Controls			
Age → Sponsorship Response	0.01	1.18	0.23
Sponsor Image → Sponsorship Response	0.13	1.58	0.12
Sponsor Image → Perceived Fit	0.06	0.86	0.39
Sponsor Image → Attributions	0.12	1.07	0.28
Structural Model Fit Indexes*			
Satorra-Bentler $\chi^2_{(229)} = 307.2, p < 0.01$			
RMSEA = 0.048; CFI = 0.96; TLI – 0.96; SRMR = 0.049			
Variance Explained			
Response: $R^2 = 0.45$; Fit: $R^2 = 0.34$; Attribution: $R^2 = 0.13$.			

*Model goodness of fit indexes are for the hypothesized model and don't include the attribution to response path, which was included to test for full mediation. Path estimates and significance test do account for this path.

complexity of the fit-matching task exceeds the level of cognitive resources available to the consumer, social identification may still lead directly to favorable sponsorship response, acting as a heuristic cue confirming the need for a dual processing perspective in understanding sponsorship response.

Although existing research has established the importance of sponsor–event fit in driving favorable sponsorship response, most research has manipulated congruence on a purely functional basis, creating a dichotomous variable for ANOVA-based tests. With a few exceptions, the measurement of individual fit perceptions has not been a chief concern. Consequently, past research has viewed fit merely as a condition rather than an essential variable, thereby preventing the development of more nuanced conceptualizations of fit and providing little understanding of the individual and contextual factors that influence fit perceptions. An over-preponderance of such designs has narrowed the theoretical scope of this stream and diminished the relevance of much sponsorship effects research (eg. Andrews 2007). This study, in contrast, measures individual perceptions of sponsor–event fit, enabling better understanding of the cognitive processes associated in generating fit perceptions in this uniquely involving context.

Prior experimental research has clearly conveyed the importance of fit as a driver of sponsorship response, consistent with congruence-based explanations for other marketing phenomena. Recent research suggests, however, that congruence may be formed concurrently on a variety of non-exclusionary bases, such as image-based fit (Fleck & Quester, 2007; Poon & Prendergast, 2006). Further, empirically speaking, the level of functional fit for most sponsor and team or event relationships may be fairly ambiguous. Thus, dichotomizing this construct by experimentally manipulating extreme levels of functional fit precludes investigation of perceived fit drivers as well as the contexts and techniques by which such perceptions might be enhanced. With the exception of those instances when the nature of fit is patently obvious, i.e., based upon sponsors' products playing a pivotal role in the activity itself, individual perceptions of fit are likely to vary in accordance with consumer experience and involvement with either the sponsor or the event. By considering fit perceptions, researchers are better positioned to identify the contexts and tactics by which fit perceptions and subsequent sponsorship response can be bolstered.

In this study, measuring fit perceptions, as opposed to experimentally manipulating fit, the central mediating role by locating this variable within a more complex nomological network to be highlighted (Iacobucci et al., 2007). Indeed, the results presented here offer support for an attribution → fit → response sequential linkage. This is in noted contrast to Rifon et al. (2004), who manipulated levels of functional fit in an attempt to demonstrate how an incongruent sponsorship match may result in negative attributions of sponsor motives. Future research aimed at investigating the processes by which fit perceptions are formed and strengthened in this highly involving context may clarify and build upon the findings of earlier research and aid in identifying potential differences in response to functional versus image-based fit perceptions.

This study focused on social identification as a key exogenous construct, a variable that appears to influence the level and content of cognitive processing. Social identity theory suggests an individual's possessions, and by implication their purchase behaviors, are a reflection of one's sense of self. That is, consumers are attracted to products and services that are consistent with, and enable the enactment of, the various social identities which make up the self (Kleine, Kleine, & Kernan, 1993). It has similarly been suggested that consumers purchase and consume products as a form of impression management to influence the important ascriptions others make to them (e.g., Netermeyer, Bearden, & Teel, 1992). By sponsoring teams and events closely related to the social identities held by key target markets, sponsorship-related activities may serve to establish and strengthen the salience of that particular identity in the course of consumer decision making (Arnett, German, & Hunt, 2003). Thus, it would seem likely that for certain consumers and for certain types of purchase decisions, the centrality of the social identity can lead to the sponsorship becoming a central attribute. Sponsor-related activities for highly identified individuals are largely in keeping with their personal interests and goals. As such individuals are willing to devote greater cognitive resources in evaluating related information, it is easier for them to identify a basis for strong fit between sponsor and event.

Research findings presented here suggest the effects of social identification on fit perceptions and response are in part channeled by an individual's attributions of sponsor motives. This study indicates highly identified individuals are more likely to attribute favorable motives to the sponsoring firm, resulting in stronger fit perceptions. Future work should continue to examine other cognition-rooted factors that could mediate the link between social identification and response. For example, high social identification may serve to inhibit the use of persuasion knowledge as it relates to the firm's products and services (Campbell & Kirmani, 2000). Alternatively, highly identified individuals may tend to view sponsors as more credible sources, motivating them to devote greater resources to processing advertising messages and leading to more favorable attitudes (Eisend, 2007).

It is noted that the indirect effect of social identification on response was also significant ($t = 3.12$, $p < 0.01$), with the total sum of the standardized indirect paths (0.181) roughly equal to that of the direct social identification to response path ($\beta = 0.176$). This supports the idea that social identification may influence persuasion by motivating elaboration or by acting as a heuristic cue. However, attitudes formed through high elaboration are generally considered to be more predictive of information processing and behavior, more stable over time, and more resistant to counter-persuasion efforts (Petty & Cacioppo, 1986). Therefore, managers should seek ways to promote the central processing of sponsorship information, either by activating the sponsorship in a manner that serves to reinforce patrons' social identification with the event or through clearer articulation of the logic underlying the sponsor–event connection (Cornwell et al., 2006). Such leveraging activities should in turn lead to more favorable attributions and greater fit perceptions, and ultimately to more favorable behavioral response. This may be achieved, for example, by tying the sponsor to financial contributions (e.g., scholarships, ticket discounts), through support for community-based programs (e.g., reading campaigns, tickets for underprivileged children), or through exclusive offers and premiums. Conversely, perceptions of sponsor sincerity may be at risk if promotional activities are too overt in advancing the commercial objectives of the sponsor.

For managers of sponsored properties, results suggest that they must work diligently to prevent the dilution of social identification amongst activity devotees. Sponsors are typically offered some level of category exclusivity as part of their rights package. However, having too many sponsors or not providing broad enough exclusivity may overly complicate the fit-matching task, even for consumers with high levels of cognitive resources. Relative to ambush marketing tactics, aggressive protection of contractual rights by sponsors against ambush marketers may inadvertently draw attention to the commercial goals of the sponsorship. Sponsorship property managers must protect sponsors by putting together distinct, hard-to-emulate rights for sponsors and conducting a sponsor recognition program that makes it difficult for ambush marketers to confuse customers (Ukman, 2008). In the event ambush marketing does occur, sponsorship properties must have prepared plans in place to police violators themselves (Meenaghan, 1998). By minimizing the degree of sponsor clutter and limiting their program's susceptibility to ambush marketing, organizations should be able to improve fit perceptions and enhance sponsorship outcomes for their clients.

LIMITATIONS AND FUTURE RESEARCH

Implications of this study should be evaluated with full understanding of several limitations. While the use of scenarios was consistent with standards established in earlier research (e.g., Johar & Pham, 2001), there are certainly instances in which consumers will be exposed to new sponsorship information in other ways. Like much experimental research, the design cannot fully reflect reality. With regard to generalizability, although the study did not use a student sample, students did recruit study participants. Consequently, the sample is younger and more skewed toward males than the general population. However, the sample does closely correspond to the highly sought 25–34 demographic, a segment widely considered a critical age group where brand attitudes and lifelong consumer purchasing patterns are favorably influenced. Thus, despite limitations, the sample seems appropriate, given the context of the study. Of course, generalizability might be strengthened by utilizing a broader sampling frame.

In addition, this study examined a single sponsor and event. Certainly, additional research incorporating different types of sponsors and events would bolster study findings. While sports-related sponsorship currently represents approximately two-thirds of sponsorship spending, other types of sponsorships are rapidly growing. Going beyond the sports-sponsorship environment and testing this resource-matching based model in other types of sponsorships, for example, relating to social causes, music or the arts, would further enhance the understanding and generalizability of the results. The fact that the types of processes used were not actually measured is an additional limitation. Theoretical assumptions of the ELM and cognitive resource matching were used to develop the hypotheses and to draw conclusions. Although these theories are well accepted in the research, utilizing a thought-eliciting methodology or similar task to measure elaboration could have provided stronger evidence of the processes used in fit perceptions.

This study is one of the first to consider that there are dual processes at work in sponsorship response highlighting the importance of both affective (peripheral) and cognitive (central) mechanisms in influencing sponsorship outcomes. Variables like social identification can work through the typical meaning transfer model to directly influence sponsor response, but this research indicates that these variables can also serve to facilitate cognitive processing. Because central processing is thought to drive stronger and more enduring attitudes and behaviors, the study offers an important enhancement to existing sponsorship theory. Future research may extend these findings by investigating the individual traits and situational contexts which strengthen or weaken the relationship between motivation to process information and cognitive elaboration, in the form of generating fit perceptions and attributions of sponsor motives. Certainly, one could envision an experimental study in which the ability of groups to elaborate was manipulated (e.g., by playing loud music in the background). Under such instances, central route processing should be much weaker. Depending upon whether the manipulation activated a relevant social identity (e.g., playing a video clip featuring their favored team), the link between social identification and response could be strengthened or weakened.

The introduction of temporal effects would also be of keen interest to scholars and practitioners. For instance, it seems quite possible that the timing of an announcement may help to strengthen fit perceptions (e.g., Butterball's sponsorship of a Thanksgiving event). If the extent of elaboration decays over time, future research might also investigate how the effects of the passage of time from the initial exposure effects fit perceptions, attribution of sponsor motive, and sponsorship response. Such research has significant implications on both the timing of sponsorship announcements and subsequent activation and leveraging activities.

Further, the study is amongst but a few that examines actual perceptions of perceived sponsor fit, as opposed to experimentally manipulating fit, and is also among the first to investigate drivers of fit perceptions within a sponsorship context. In introducing this relatively parsimonious framework, this research hopes to add insight into understanding the sponsorship phenomenon. Of course, the notion that there may be other important drivers of attributions, fit perceptions, and sponsorship response that were not considered in this study is not excluded. With that said, it appears that many of such individual traits (e.g., need for cognition) and contextual factors (e.g., product involvement) would fit well with the resource-matching perspective introduced in this study. Future research investigating the role of cognition in sponsorship information processing should only deepen the understanding of sponsorship effects.

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